

NIGHT FREIGHT

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Original work, bundled with Ripple

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demo-scripts/01-night-freight

1 EXT. HARBOUR ROAD - NIGHT 1

Rain. A chain-link fence runs the length of the frame. Beyond it, stacked containers go up four high, orange and rust.

A sodium lamp buzzes over the gate. Everything under it is the colour of weak tea.

2 EXT. DEPOT GATE - CONTINUOUS 2

A guard hut, lit from inside. TOMAS ADEYEMI, 50s, reads a paperback with the spine broken back on itself.

A car horn. Two short taps.

TOMAS
(not looking up)
Badge.

3 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - NIGHT 3

Strip lighting. Six monitors, four of them dead. MARA OKONJO, 30s, in a grey parka she has not taken off in nine hours, works a keyboard with two fingers.

The parka is soaked at the shoulders. She has not noticed.

A radio on the desk crackles.

VOICE ON RADIO (V.O.)
Dispatch, this is Seventeen. I'm at
the weighbridge and the weighbridge
says I'm empty.

MARA
Are you empty?

VOICE ON RADIO (V.O.)
I am extremely not empty.

MARA
Then the weighbridge is lying. Come
round.

4 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - CONTINUOUS 4

Mara pulls a clipboard off a nail. Runs a finger down the manifest.

She stops. Goes back up. Down again.

MARA
Huh.

5 EXT. WEIGHBRIDGE - NIGHT 5

A twelve-metre trailer rests on the plate. The display reads 0.00 T in red.

DEV RAMIREZ, 40s, steps down from the cab, hood up against the rain.

DEV
Nine times out of ten it's the load cell.

MARA (O.S.)
And the tenth time?

DEV
Somebody's been at it.

6 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - NIGHT 6

CALLIE VOSS, 50s, night supervisor, comes in shaking water off an umbrella she did not need.

CALLIE
Log it as a fault. Engineering comes Thursday.

MARA
It's Monday.

CALLIE
Then log it as a fault and go home on time for once.

7 EXT. WEIGHBRIDGE - NIGHT 7

Dev crouches at the edge of the plate. Runs his hand along the seam.

His hand comes back wet and black.

DEV
That's not rain.

8 INT. DEPOT CANTEEN - NIGHT 8

Vending machine light. Mara sets down two coffees.

Dev wipes his hands on a paper towel. Across the back of his right hand, a raised scar runs from the knuckle of his index finger to the wrist. Old. Silvered.

MARA
That from here?

DEV
(covering it)
Rigging accident. Different yard.

MARA
Which yard?

DEV
One that doesn't exist anymore.

9 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - NIGHT 9

Mara, still in the grey parka, spreads three manifests across the desk.

Three trailers. Three weights. Three signatures, all the same hand.

MARA
(to herself)
Same pen, even.

10 EXT. CONTAINER STACK - NIGHT 10

Torchlight between the rows. Mara walks the aisle, counting doors.

She reaches container 4-4-1. The seal is intact. She photographs it.

11 EXT. CONTAINER STACK - CONTINUOUS 11

She walks two rows over. Container 4-4-2.

The seal is intact here too. But the number stamped in the lead is the same number as the last one.

MARA
That's not possible.

12 INT. GUARD HUT - NIGHT 12

Tomas turns a page.

MARA (O.S.)
Who signed for the four-forties?

TOMAS
Gate log's on the hook.

The hook is empty.

- 13 EXT. DEPOT YARD - NIGHT 13
Mara crosses the open yard, head down, rain running off the parka hood.
Behind her, in the dark, a container door swings a hand's width and stops.
- 14 EXT. LOADING DOCK - NIGHT 14
Rain sheets off the awning. Two pallet jacks, one dead forklift, the blue sedan idles by the gate, wipers going.
Under the sodium wash the whole dock is one colour.
Mara comes down the steps and gets in the car.
- 15 INT. BLUE SEDAN - CONTINUOUS 15
She doesn't start driving. Watches the dock through the wipers.
The container door swings again. Stops again.
- 16 INT. BLUE SEDAN - LATER 16
Mara's phone, face up on the passenger seat. A photo of the duplicate seal.
She types a message. Deletes it. Types it again.
- 17 EXT. HARBOUR ROAD - NIGHT 17
Headlights sweep past the fence and keep going.
- 18 INT. MARA'S FLAT - NIGHT 18
Small. Clean. She hangs the grey parka on the back of the door, where it drips onto newspaper laid down for that purpose.
- 19 INT. MARA'S FLAT - CONTINUOUS 19
She spreads the photographs on the kitchen table. Four seals. Two numbers.
- 20 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - DAY 20
Daylight makes the office worse. Callie has the fault log open.

CALLIE
You went into the stack.

MARA
I counted doors.

CALLIE
You went into the stack at two in
the morning on your own.

Behind them, through the window, the dead forklift stands
where it stood last night.

MARA
Who has seal stock?

CALLIE
Nobody has seal stock. Seal stock is
sealed.

21 INT. RECORDS ROOM - DAY 21

Box files to the ceiling. Mara pulls 2024, Q3.
Every gate log for eleven weeks is missing its Tuesday.

22 EXT. DEPOT CAR PARK - DAY 22

Mara crosses to the blue sedan, keys out, parka over one arm.
Dev is leaning on the wing.

DEV
You photographed a seal.

MARA
I photographed four.

DEV
Put them somewhere that isn't your
phone.

23 INT. BLUE SEDAN - CONTINUOUS 23

Dev gets in the passenger side without being asked. Water off
his jacket onto the seat.

DEV
Drive somewhere.

MARA
Where?

DEV
Anywhere with a camera on it.

24 EXT. PETROL STATION - DAY 24

Fluorescent under the canopy. Four cameras. Mara parks under all of them.

25 INT. BLUE SEDAN - CONTINUOUS 25

DEV
Eleven weeks of Tuesdays.

MARA
You knew.

DEV
I knew a number was wrong. I didn't
know which number.

26 INT. PETROL STATION SHOP - DAY 26

Dev pays for two coffees. The scar on his hand catches the light as he counts change.

The CASHIER, 20s, looks at it a half-second too long.

DEV
(under his breath)
Yeah.

27 INT. DISPATCH OFFICE - NIGHT 27

Mara logs in. Her access to the gate system returns a red banner.

PERMISSIONS UPDATED. CONTACT YOUR SUPERVISOR.

28 INT. CALLIE'S OFFICE - NIGHT 28

CALLIE
It's not me.

MARA
It says supervisor.

CALLIE
It says supervisor because the
system only knows two words.

Callie looks at the door. Closes it.

CALLIE (CONT'D)
Go home, Mara.

29 EXT. DEPOT YARD - NIGHT 29

Mara walks out. Tomas watches her go from the hut and does not read his book.

30 INT. GUARD HUT - CONTINUOUS 30

Tomas picks up a phone that is not his phone.

31 EXT. LOADING DOCK - NIGHT 31

The blue sedan waits by the gate with the engine off and the lights off.

Mara, inside it, watches a container door open properly this time.

Two men she does not recognise walk a pallet jack down the ramp.

32 EXT. CONTAINER STACK - NIGHT 32

Torchlight. Different torch. Two of them.

33 EXT. LOADING DOCK - NIGHT 33

The pallet jack goes up the ramp of a trailer with no plates.

34 INT. BLUE SEDAN - CONTINUOUS 34

Mara films it through the windscreen. Her hands are steady.
Her breathing is not.

35 INT. MARA'S FLAT - NIGHT 35

The door is open four inches. She did not leave it open four inches.

36 INT. MARA'S FLAT - CONTINUOUS 36

Nothing is broken. Nothing is missing. The photographs on the kitchen table have been squared into a neat stack.

That is worse.

37 EXT. HARBOUR ROAD - DAWN 37

Mara walks the length of the fence in the grey parka, phone to her ear.

MARA
(into phone)
Then who does investigate it?

38 INT. DEV'S KITCHEN - DAY 38

Dev, no jacket, pours coffee.

DEV

Port authority takes it if there's a
customs number attached. There's
never a customs number attached.
That's the design.

MARA

So it's nobody.

DEV

It's nobody until it's a body.

39 INT. DEV'S KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS 39

Mara sets her phone on the counter. Plays the footage.

Dev watches it twice.

DEV

The one on the left is the one who
signs.

40 INT. RECORDS ROOM - DAY 40

Mara pulls 2024, Q4. Tuesdays intact.

She checks the shelf above. 2025, Q1. Tuesdays gone.

She looks up. On the top shelf, a box that is not a box file:
seal stock, unopened, forty units.

41 EXT. DEPOT YARD - NIGHT 41

Rain again. Mara crosses the yard with the seal box under the
parka.

Headlights swing into the gate. She drops behind the dead
forklift.

A trailer with no plates rolls past two metres away.

42 EXT. DEPOT YARD - CONTINUOUS 42

The trailer stops. A door opens. Boots on wet concrete.

Mara does not move.

TOMAS (O.S.)

She's not out here.

A long beat.

TOMAS (O.S.) (CONT'D)
I said she's not out here.

The boots go back. The door shuts.

43 EXT. DEPOT GATE - NIGHT 43

Tomas raises the barrier for the plateless trailer. Watches it go. Then lowers the barrier and walks back to the hut without looking at the yard.

44 EXT. LOADING DOCK - NIGHT 44

Mara comes out from behind the forklift with the box.

The blue sedan is where she left it. Dev is standing beside it, hood down, rain on his face.

He puts out his right hand for the box. The scar shows.

DEV
Give it here.

Mara looks at the hand. Does not move.

MARA
Which yard, Dev?

Off Dev, not answering.

FADE OUT.